CHAPTER 4

SOUTHPORT

30 June 2024, 4:05pm

LANCASHIRE vs NOTTINGHAMSHIRE,
County Championship, *Southport*

Lancashire 353/9 dec. / Nottinghamshire 126 & 270/4 dec. (following on)

Match drawn

First innings: **J Anderson 16–3–35–7**

It's so cold. The kind of cold that makes you forget what you are doing, cuts off feeling from your toes. For two days, I've been hiding from it all in the dressing room. Only a few months ago, I was playing at the bottom of a mountain in Dharamshala in India, a cricket ground that had not been built when I started playing. The ground was flanked by white snow-capped mountains, lending a bizarre sense of foreboding to the occasion. I'd become locked in a battle with Shubman Gill during that Test. He'd just brought up his century and ran past me and told me it was time to retire. I got him out two balls later. I said nothing, just felt him watching me as he walked past.

Not long after, I'd taken my 700th Test wicket. Kuldeep Yadav. Being a bowler and not a new-era batting icon, he'd been more self-effacing about the whole thing and said to me before I took the wicket, 'I just know I'm going to be your 700th wicket, aren't I?' I smiled and half shrugged, half nodded. It was strange because people would constantly ask that too – when are you going to get 700? I didn't know. It didn't really work like that. I felt like telling them, 'I don't get to choose.' All I cared about was playing games of cricket, winning games of cricket for England. It's still disturbing